

The Cost of Time

By Abdullah Mohammad

In economics, there's a concept known as opportunity cost, which is the potential benefit, profit, or value lost when choosing one alternative over another, representing the cost of the next-best option forgone. Because resources like time, money, and effort are limited, every decision involves trading off one opportunity for another.

Time can be easily represented by the concept of opportunity cost, as it is upon us how we choose to spend it. Time is like an asset that has the ability to be invested in ourselves, in a place, or in a thing.

An example of investing into time is for example, you have a laptop that has a Hard Disk Drive (or HDD), which runs on disk plates and takes a long time to boot and store data in it, which could lead to precious time being wasted. Whereas if one invests in a Solid State Drive (or SSD) for instance, which is based on memory and takes 2-3 seconds to start up and has marginally faster speeds, we have made an investment in our time by saving it. Although SSDs are more expensive than traditional hard drives, this comes at the cost of money, and those conscious of time would prefer to save it rather than waste it.

If I recount my life experiences at this ripe age of 16, there is something I regret deeply: it's not taking the right opportunity at the right time. Not studying for midterms at the right time. Not giving due attention to a particular topic at the time. Being given an opportunity, yet not taking it. Regret doesn't come immediately, it only comes later, when everything has passed by.

Aside from this example, time is a gift from Allah (swt) given to us, Muslims, we all have limited time on this earth. One day, we'd have to go back to Him and answer for what we've done on this earth. Now this time we hold as a youth (the 13-20 year old age bracket) is one of the most vital parts of our lives. Society tells us to enjoy it, that we have a lot of time, that we can always repent later, and to "enjoy" your life, but this life is nothing but a delusion.

Now, Islam doesn't say explicitly to not "enjoy" our youth, of course we are allowed to enjoy it. But what does it warn against? Heedlessness. That we don't get lost in this worldly life, but rather benefit both lives.

As Allah (swt) says in the Qur'an,

"By the 'passage of' time! Surely humanity is in 'grave' loss, except those who have faith, do good, and urge each other to the truth, and urge each other to perseverance." (Surah Al-Asr)

Death is something that can come at any time, it doesn't see whether we are in our old age or we are just starting our youth. And even when death comes, what will you have to show your Lord? That I spent most of my time on Instagram reels, instead of doing something that could've benefitted both my worldly life and the hereafter?

So I ask myself, and you, the reader, to reevaluate what we are even living for. Are we living as people who are going to abide in this world as if we are never going to leave it, or as travellers? That one day, we'd leave this earth, just like we came here: with nothing.